Shira Kates

Staff Product Designer / AI & Agentic UX / Design Leadership

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SUMMARY

Product designer and design leader specializing in AI and agentic experiences, with 15+ years designing enterprise and consumer products. At Google I led design for the first generative AI product shipped from Google Cloud: natural language to a fully functional app. Hands-on across interaction design, conversational design, prototyping, and UX research, while leading multidisciplinary teams and innovation programs. I build working agents and prototypes with Claude, Google AI Studio, Google Agent Studio, Figma Make, and Magic Patterns.

EXPERIENCE

Staff UX Lead, AppSheet (Google Cloud AI) / Google — May 2022 – May 2026 / Remote

- Led UX platform-wide for the multidisciplinary team (interaction, research, content) through 4x MAU growth and 40%+ sustained YoY growth; made UX a strategic partner to product and engineering. 2025 manager ratings 4.58–4.93 of 5; one report promoted to L6; team presented at Cloud NEXT and Google I/O.
- Led design for Gemini-powered app creation, the first generative AI product shipped from Google Cloud: natural language to a functional app, with real-time schema editing from a conversational prompt. 2,000+ active AI-built apps, 80M Vertex AI tokens in a month, and a 400% increase in AI feature usage (1,500 Gemini tasks/day, 95% positive satisfaction).
- Led UX for Chat Apps in Google Workspace (1,800+ monthly deployments) and AppSheet Database (38% lift in 28-day MAU); both won Cloud Tech Impact Awards.
- Designed the conversational experience as it moved from rule-based dialogue to LLM-powered tools: intent taxonomy, response patterns, error recovery, and confirmation strategies merging conversational and visual editing in one surface.
- Authored the Evolved Agents / Frontline Worker vision, a multimodal model where agents adapt their surface (voice, thin UI, rich UI) to context. Presented AI/UX strategy to the Google Cloud CEO; shaped VP-level Cloud AI roadmaps.
- Defined AI Verbs, natural language automation primitives that let users express complex logic conversationally: 200% usage increase, 2M+ AI tokens across 70+ apps.
- Founded and ran EQ Week, a bi-yearly AI innovation hackathon: 35+ participants, 18 projects, 7 advanced to roadmap, including AI Verbs, which debuted at Cloud NEXT.

UX Consultant, Assistive AI / Course Hero — Aug 2021 – May 2022 / Freelance

- Established the conversational AI design practice for an AI homework help product: UX writing guidelines, interaction patterns, and design system components for human-AI interaction, validated through user research.

Chief Design Officer / CivicActions — Sep 2019 – Jun 2021 / Remote

- Hired as Content Designer; promoted to CDO within a year. Led UX, content strategy, design systems, and accessibility for federal programs including the VA, CMS, NSF, and USDS.
- UX lead on the winning bid for a $25M Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services contract; designed and prototyped a working experience in 10 days.

Founder & Principal / Snapdragon Strategy — Aug 2008 – Jul 2019 / San Diego

- Independent UX strategy and design consultancy run alongside full-time roles: research, content design, prototyping, and product strategy for startups and enterprise clients in fintech, edtech, SaaS, and consumer apps. Coached leaders and design teams, including NMSU Arrowhead Center accelerator cohorts (2018–2019).

Director of Product Design / Yahoo (BrightRoll) — May 2014 – Aug 2017 / San Francisco

- Led UX design and research for BrightRoll's demand-side ad platform through its $640M acquisition by Yahoo; grew scope from one product to four platforms and built the platform design system.
- Led the hackathon team that created the first mobile app for ad campaign management; it became an official product and led to a US patent application.

Senior UX Content Designer, Knowledge UX / Google (Contract) — Oct 2013 – May 2014 / Mountain View

/ Designed interactions and content for Google Maps and immersive search; set language standards across Maps, Search, and Identity.

Earlier: Senior Strategist, UX, Accenture (2012–2013) / Product Manager, Content and Publishing, AT&T (2010–2012)

SKILLS

AI & Agentic Design: Agentic UX, Conversational AI Design, Human-AI Interaction, LLM Product Design, Multimodal UX, Prompt Design, Intent Architecture, Voice UX

Product Design: Interaction Design, End-to-End Design, Prototyping, Design Systems, UX Research, UX Writing, Content Design, Accessibility, 0-to-1 Products

Leadership: Team Leadership, Hiring & Talent Development, AI Vision & Roadmap, Cross-functional Alignment, Executive Storytelling, Hackathons

Tools: Figma, Figma Make, Gemini Enterprise Agent Designer, Google AI Studio, Claude, ChatGPT, Magic Patterns, GitHub Copilot, VoiceFlow, NotebookLM

RECOGNITION & EDUCATION

/ Google Cloud Tech Impact Awards x2 (2023) / US Patent Application: Managing Ad Campaigns via Mobile Devices (2015)

/ Speaker: AI Talks / One Club for Creativity (2026), Bot Boundaries podcast, Disruptive AI-UX Summit, SDXD, UCSD Design

/ UCSD Design Lab mentor and judge; guest lecturer, CCA and Parsons / Hudson Institute Executive Coaching Certification (2025)

/ MBA, Design Strategy, California College of the Arts / BA, English Literature, Skidmore College